EUROPE'S BOAT PEOPLE: A REFUGEE CRISIS IN EUROPE UNFOLDING

Since the World War II, the world has not experienced such a massive emergency refugee crisis where thousands of "boat people" from Iraq, Afghanistan, Syria and war-torn Libya and Somalia are seeking asylum or have set up migrant camps or are heading towards many European Countries like Greece, Germany, Italy and others. This reminds the world of the "boat people" crisis after the Vietnam War in the 1970s. Around 1975 and even over next two decades more than 3 million people fled from Vietnam, Cambodia and Laos after Communist victories in these countries. Unwilling to live under Communist regimes, people started fleeing these countries. Almost 80,000 Vietnamese according to UNHCR Reports fled by boats. It was a massive exodus during peacetime. A large number of people died even before reaching shores from pirate attacks, drowning or starvation.

But current crisis is unprecedented and of a larger volume. At least 60 million people have been displaced because of war, conflict, persecution and unrest in Afghanistan, Iraq, Somalia, Syria, Yemen and elsewhere. More than
4 million refugees have escaped Syria where Civil War has out-broken and has killed people in large numbers. Since the beginning of the conflict in Syria in 2011, two million Syrians have been registered as refugees with the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR). Most have crossed over to other countries and live in shanties, camps or poor local communities in Turkey, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq and Egypt to mention a few. Others have tried to reach some other countries via sea-route. The exodus trends show the direction towards Europe. Greece is becoming a first destination for Syrian escaping the civil war back at home. Many are taking a direct but a longer sea route to Italy. In 2014 Italy was mainly the destination of refugees from Eritrea and Syria. However, a sizeable number have been given refugee status by mid-2014.

The UN reports that since the war began, more than 500,000 Syrians (of the 4.2 million Syrian refugees overall) have applied for asylum in Europe. Sweden accepted around 10,000 Syrian asylum-